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SWEEPING DEMANDS
Protesting junior doctors march towards Swasthya Bhavan in Kolkata, Sept. 10

WEST BENGAL

Medics Win First Round

By Arkamoy Datta Majumdar

tice for the victim—kept the pressure up by saying the doctors can resume work only if assured proper security. The state duly submitted to the SC its detailed plan to ensure the safety of doctors.

Meanwhile in Kolkata, from their newest bastion—the protest site on the street in front of Swasthya Bhawan, headquarters of the state health department—junior doctors turned down chief minister Mamata Banerjee's calls for negotiations twice, stressing that any meeting has to be videographed to ensure "transparency" and rejecting the state's reason for refusal that the matter was sub judice in the SC. Their resolute stance forced Mamata to personally come on September 14 and assure them of justice. A breakthrough came on September 16, when the two parties finally met, softening the impasse by agreeing on stenographers taking minutes. In a stunning victory for the doctors and in partial fulfilment of their demands, Mamata agreed to remove Kolkata police commissioner Vineet Goyal, director of medical education Kaustav Nayek, director of health services (DHS) Debasish Haldar, and Abhishek Gupta, the deputy commissioner (DC), North, Kolkata Police. When Mamata requested the protesters to resume work, they said the strike would continue till the promises were executed.

Goyal was replaced by Manoj Kumar Verma as Kolkata's top cop, while Dipak Sarkar will replace Abhishek Gupta as DC, North. Haldar has been replaced by his deputy Swapan Soren as DHS in charge.

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The doctors, who have continued to strike despite the Supreme Court asking them to resume their duties, are sticking to their "five-point demand"—punishing those responsible for the crime; strict action against former RGKMCH principal Sandip Ghosh, the resignations of Goyal and the DCPs North and Central (Kolkata), the elimination of the alleged "threat culture" in Bengal's medical colleges and adequate security measures for healthcare workers. Ghosh was arrested by the CBI on September 14 for allegedly destroying evidence and is already in the dock on graft charges. Along with Haldar and Nayek, the doctors also want the removal of health secretary Narayan Swaroop Nigam. "Not even one of the pests which are eating up the public health system of our state can be spared," a protesting doctor tells INDIA TODAY.

The nondescript street in front of Swasthya Bhawan has assumed an air of a settled habitation since the sit-in demonstration started on September 10. The protesters want for nothing: food of all manner, bio-toilets, electricity connections through generator sets to tarpaulin shelters and a regular supply of clothes to keep dry in the heavy monsoon rain are in abundance. Tokens of support and solidarity have been pouring in from across the country. "We have your support and that is why we are able to continue this fight," Amrita Bhattacharya, a junior resident doctor said in a video message. She is a member of the West Bengal Junior Doctors' Front (WBJDF), which is spearheading the movement. Though there have been attempts by the Trinamool Congress to malign the movement by tagging it with Opposition political parties, it remains proudly apolitical.

The CM has led and resisted numerous political movements. "But an apolitical, leaderless protest that has the support of the common people is alien to her," says political analyst Biswajit Bhattacharya. Right now, she has seen merit in making a conciliatory move. ■